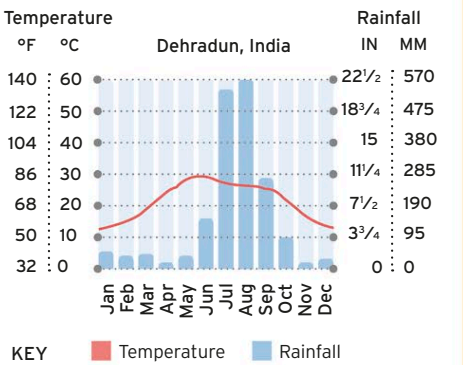




CLIMATE

Heat and humidity characterize the Terai-Duar all year round, but temperatures often rise to 104°F (40°C) in the late dry season. Annual monsoon rains result in floods throughout the region, renewing vital deposits of fertile silt.



◁ RIVER CROSSING

A rare Indian rhinoceros cools off in a river in Nepal's Royal Chitwan National Park. Of all five rhino species, this one is most at home in water.

Siberian Tundra

A cold and often frozen landscape lying mostly above the Arctic Circle, where life persists even in the most inhospitable of conditions



Northeastern Russia's Siberian tundra ranges from the edge of the taiga in the south (see pp.254–55) through the central region of the north coast and eastward as far as the Chukchi Peninsula.

Long winters where temperatures plunge to -40°F (-40°C) are the norm in Siberian tundra, while summers are short and cool, warming to just 54°F (12°C). Winds blow at speeds of up to 60 mph (100kph), and the frozen soil layer known as permafrost (see p.175) can be as thick as 2,000 ft (600 m). Yet clumps of grasses, fungi, and low-growing shrubs manage to survive, providing a vital source of nourishment for swarms of insects and migrating bird and mammal species.

▷ SNOW SURVIVOR

Insulated by two coats of hair, reindeers survive on sedges, mosses, and lichens, which they find even beneath the snow.



▷ FIELDS OF COTTON

Arctic cotton grass grows in wet ground and blooms during the short summers, when it provides food for reindeer calves.

